



Fellow Chennaite Praggnanandhaa is seeded second, while Arjun is third. It is not often that you see all the top three seeds being Indians in a major event of a truly global sport.

The World Cup is one of the biggest events in chess. When it comes to individual competition, it is second only in stature to the World Championship. Reigning champion Magnus Carlsen is not defending his crown this time. In the last edition of the event, held in Baku, Azerbaijan, he defeated Praggnanandhaa in the final.

His absence may take some sheen off the World Cup, but that doesn't make the tournament any less interesting. The Norwegian, who recently became a father for the first time, isn't particularly keen to play classical chess these days, preferring rapid, blitz or freestyle formats.

With Carlsen staying away from Goa, along with World No. 2 Hikaru Nakamura and No. 3 Fabiano Caruana, the World Cup takes on an even more open look. Not that a

knockout event is expected to progress according to the seeding — all it takes is one bad move for a top player to crash out of the tournament. In chess tournaments played in the Swiss or round-robin format — as is often the case — one gets multiple chances to bounce back into contention after a setback or two.

Praggnanandhaa starts as one of the favourites, not just because he was the finalist in the last World Cup. The 20-year-old has played some sparkling chess this year and won a few significant tournaments, including the prestigious Wijk aan Zee. Though he had some poor results after finishing as runner-up at the 2023 World Cup, he told this writer in an interview how he had worked hard on his game and how it paid dividends. Little wonder he is ranked World No. 5 right now.

Arjun meanwhile is a step above at No. 4. He will also be motivated by the slots available for the Candidates Tournament — the qualifier for the

Heavy duty: R Praggnanandhaa (left) and Arjun Erigaisi (right), are seeded second and third, respectively, in the tournament. MARIA EMELIANOVA/FIDE

World Championship — from the World Cup. He is well down the ladder in the FIDE Circuit (another route to the Candidates), and a good show at the World Cup is his best shot (the top three from Goa will qualify). Praggnanandhaa is leading the Circuit table, that too by a comfortable margin.

It is not just the terrific trio of Indian chess that the host nation is pinning its hopes on. **Players such as Aravindh Chithambaram, Nihal Sarin and Vidit Gujrathi are also expected to advance to the latter stages of the tournament.** The other Indians in the fray include Pentala Harikrishna, S.L. Narayanan, Karthikeyan Murali, V. Pranav and Goa's own Leon Mendonca.

And there is another Indian who will very much be in the limelight: